

The Delivery

In a memory of Sergeant Briggs and Blackhoof Witherspine

The dream came the way bad dreams always did — not loud, not dramatic, just wrong.

Briggs - standing somewhere - stone underfoot. Mist. And then something moved, and Briggs turned, and there was a blade, and blood, and pain...

Blackhoof woke up.

The tent was dark. Around him the camp breathed its usual night sounds — distant fire, someone snoring three tents over, the particular silence of an army that had decided morning was still someone else's problem.

He lay still for a moment and waited for the dream to give him something more specific. It didn't. Just the image, already dissolving: Briggs turning, the blade, and then nothing, the way dreams ended when they had made their point and didn't feel the need to elaborate.

He stared at the tent ceiling.

Briggs had left yesterday morning with Orehoof to the town. Two days. Straightforward courier run. Back by tomorrow evening at the latest. Briggs was clear - time to teach other blockhead, when this one was starting to learn. No amount of neighing couldn't broke gnome's decision when was made.

Blackhoof stared up for another few minutes. He got up and no one could stop him.

He found Orehoof two miles past the eastern fork.

The young centaur was in the ditch at the roadside. Three enemy goblins nearby, also cold. The ground around them told the story plainly enough — the ambush had come from the left, fast, and Orehoof had turned toward it the way Briggs had told to Blackhoof a hundred times not to.

Chin up. Throat open.

Blackhoof crouched beside him for a moment. Orehoof had been in the army since the same day. He had been enthusiastic about everything, and had not yet learned that enthusiasm required calibration. Well, Orehoof is here, but his sergeant not.

Blackhoof stood there, with his weapons ready, when someone appeared from a bush. A goblin, wrong uniform. Centaur swung the hammer before the brain could discuss it with eyes. Hammer hit, skull cracked.

At least he knew which way to search.

The tracks leading away from the ditch were fresh — booted feet, several of them, heading northeast into the scrubland. Blackhoof followed.

The trail was definitely not subtle. Two enemy goblins in the undergrowth - throat sliced, heads almost decapitated. A third one further along, this one missing a head completely.

Then the trail went uphill.

The outcrop rose maybe thirty feet from the scrubland floor — not a hill, more like a rock. Some giant may have a small stone in his shoe and just get rid of it here. Steep enough that a gnome who had reached the top with enough of a lead could make things very uncomfortable for anyone trying to follow. From up there, Blackhoof noted, you could see the surrounding scrubland in every direction. You could also, he noted further, be seen from the surrounding scrubland in every direction, which was something of a double-edged arrangement.

Six enemy goblins were currently arranged around the base of the outcrop in the patient formation of men who had decided that waiting was the correct strategy. They had water. They had supplies. They were not going anywhere.

From the top of the outcrop, nothing moved.

Blackhoof retreated into the treeline and thought about this.

The goblins at the base were relaxed. Not triumphant — they hadn't won yet — but settled. The kind of settled that came from knowing the arithmetic was in your favour. A gnome stuck on a rock with limited supplies, in the middle of nowhere. Time was their ally.

He looked at his quiver. He looked at the six goblins.

He thought about what Briggs would do, in his position. He nocked the first arrow, aimed, and released. Then he ran sideways, nocked the second, and started shouting.

"FLANKING LEFT — COVERING RIGHT — I SEE THEM, THREE AT THE BASE—"

The second arrow went before the first had landed. He was already moving again, crashing through the underbrush with considerably more noise than was strictly necessary for someone who wished to remain undetected, which was entirely the point. Two goblins down. The remaining four were on their feet, facing the treeline, facing each other, facing nowhere in particular with the urgent indecision of men who had been expecting a siege and had received an assault from an unknown quantity in an unknown direction.

"SECOND UNIT, SECURE THE TREELINE — CAVALRY ADVANCE—"

He shouted it with conviction, in the tone of a man relaying information to people who existed. The four remaining goblins made a command decision.

They left. Like one goblin, they have turned around and run away.

Blackhoof waited until the sound of their retreat had faded into the scrubland, then emerged from the treeline and ran to the base of the outcrop.

At the top of the rock, a small, dark-coated figure looked down at him.

"Took your time," said Briggs.

"I came as fast as I could."

"I had it handled."

"Mm." Blackhoof looked at the base of the outcrop. He looked back up at Briggs, who was descending the outcrop with the careful movements.

"You were on a rock," Blackhoof said.

"I had a higher ground."

"A master move, dare I say."

Briggs reached the bottom of the outcrop and looked at him with the flat expression of a man choosing his battles. He was tired — genuinely tired, the kind that came from a night without sleep on cold stone — and his coat had acquired a new collection of opinions from the scrubland, and he was clutching a sealed document and a wrapped package, both of which he had clearly declined to relinquish under any circumstances.

"Are you done?" he said.

"The image of you up there—"

"Blackhoof."

"—just sitting there waiting for rescue—"

"Blackhoof."

"—may be a bit desperate?"

"Steady," said Briggs. "I need to get on."

Blackhoof got down, with the expression of someone filing something away for later. Briggs swung himself up with the efficiency of long practice and said nothing for a moment, getting his bearings, and then said:

"Where are the others?"

Blackhoof started moving.

"What others?" he said.

A pause.

"The unit. You were shouting about flanking positions and second units advancing."

"Was I."

"You were very specific."

"Hm." Blackhoof kept moving, at a pace that discouraged pursuit. "Just me, Briggs."

Another pause, longer this time.

"Just you."

"Just me. Hence the rush. They may doublecheck."

Briggs said nothing for a moment. Behind Blackhoof's shoulders, he could feel the quality of the silence — not the flat silence he used for things he had decided not to engage with, but something different.

"Orehoof," Briggs said.

"Eastern fork. He turned wrong." Blackhoof kept his voice level. "He didn't hold his chin."

The silence that followed had a different texture.

"I should have—" Briggs started.

"You told him. I heard you tell him." Blackhoof kept moving. "Some ones take longer to learn than others."

Briggs said nothing. Blackhoof felt him settle — not comfortably, not easily, but with the weight of a man accepting something he couldn't change and filing it where he kept the other things he couldn't change. He had a shelf for those. It was not a small shelf.

"So where are the others?" Briggs said eventually.

"Told you." Sudden stiffness brought Briggs back to the moment. Something was fishy.

"You left camp without authorisation!"

"I did."

"That's a disciplinary matter."

"I'm aware."

"Tusk will—"

"Worth it," Blackhoof ended the conversation the way Briggs did when he didn't want them arguing anymore.

It was not a glorious return. Briggs never believed in glory and Blackhoof was not sure any more how much worth it would be in a few moments.

They moved through the camp to the Tusks tent. They entered.

Tusk was sitting behind the table, organising some documents. When he saw the movement his eyes met Briggs's - for a fracture of a moment something arrived and departed quickly in his face. Something bitter and not in a good way. He swallowed the taste quickly.

He looked at the sealed document and the wrapped parcel, both intact.

He said nothing. Just a small nod, then he took both deliveries and left the tent with a hurry.

Blackhoof watched him go with the faint unease of someone who had expected something and received nothing instead. He waited for a summons, a reprimand, anything that suggested his unauthorised departure had been noted and would be addressed.

Nothing came.

That evening, nothing. The next morning, nothing. Tusk looked through him at morning parade with the complete unseeing attention of a man regarding empty air.

Blackhoof stood in the line and felt the nothing land.

Not punishment, he thought. Something worse than punishment. Punishment would have meant he existed, that what he had done warranted a response, that his presence or absence registered on someone's accounting.

This was the other thing. Items in a supply ledger didn't get disciplined. They got ignored.

He found Briggs at the edge of camp that evening, where the firelight gave way to dark, doing nothing in particular with the focused attention of a man doing something very particular.

"Tusk didn't say anything," Blackhoof said. "Not a word. Not about the leave. Nothing."

"No."

Blackhoof was quiet for a moment. "That's worse, isn't it."

Briggs looked at the dark for a while. Then he reached into his coat, produced his flask, and held it out. Blackhoof took it. Drank. Handed it back.

"Well I am no fan of whipping, but..."

Briggs kept his silence.

The fire crackled between them. Somewhere across the camp, dice rattled against a wooden surface and someone laughed.

"How did you know?" Both knew what that question was addressing.

"I had a dream. " He looked at the fire. "I didn't remember the details. Just — you, and something wrong, and I woke up and I couldn't go back to sleep."

Briggs looked at him sideways.

"So you took your bow and left camp."

"Yes."

"Based on a dream."

"Based on a dream," Blackhoof confirmed, with the dignity of a man who has committed to a position and intends to hold it.

Briggs looked at him for a long moment. Then he looked back at the fire, and something moved in his face that the firelight made difficult to identify with precision, and he took a pull from the flask and said nothing for a while.

"You're welcome, Biggs," he said.

"I didn't say—"

"You were on a rock."

Briggs closed his eyes briefly, with the expression of a man making peace with something.

"Goodnight, Blacky," he said.

"Like a squirrel on her oak."

"Goodnight."

Blackhoof smiled and said nothing more, and the fire burned between them, and the camp moved around them in its usual evening business, and neither of them said anything else about dreams, or rocks, or the particular expression on a supply officer's face when something he had arranged had failed to go the way he intended.

